adjust to changing environment, Nehruvianism is still the bedrock of Indian foreign policy. In the words of Natwar Singh, Nehru ‘studied history, wrote history, made and shaped history’. [41] As an American political scientist wrote in 1958, the ‘principal source’ of Indian thinking on international affairs and the ‘high emotional content’ of Indian foreign policy are due to the ‘omnipotent influence’ of Nehru on the conduct of foreign policy and the ‘immense popular support’ given to his declarations.[42]

Most analysts agree Nehru’s greatest legacy is the underlying framework of ideas and institutions that have governed India’s external relations since 1947. Just as he received praise for laying the foundations, Nehru has also been criticized for being overly idealistic and for crafting a foreign policy with a strong moralistic tone. Under his successors, India came to be seen as a nation that judged and preached to others instead of accepting the dynamic of conflicting national interests that shapes international relations. Like the United States, India has often attracted the charge of hypocrisy in foreign policy because its proclaimed ideals do not always match its actions.

During what Paul Power describes as the ‘Age of Nehru’, moral concerns dominated a wide spectrum of diplomatic, ideological and strategic considerations.[43] Nehru’s global stature and his role in organizations like the United Nations, coupled with his championing of the anti-colonial and anti-racist cause, won India recognition from other former colonies in Africa and Asia. However, Michael Edwardes asserts that Nehru mistook ‘respect for Nehru’ as being the same as acceptance of India as a major power on the world stage and as the undisputed leader of non-aligned nations. According to Edwardes, ‘Nehru had created for India an international persona which was not congruent with her actual status as an underdeveloped country.’[44]

Nehru’s knowledge of foreign affairs was so vast that none of his contemporaries or successors ever attempted to disagree with him. The dictum of ‘Panditji [Pandit Nehru] knows best’ often prevented